



THEO 7003: Theology 1: God, Creation, and Sin

Graduate (MA): 3 credits

Fall 2026 (Aug 18th – Oct 13th) • 7pm – 8:45pm • Aiea Heights Church, Aiea HI

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Office Hours: By Appointment

§1. COURSE DESCRIPTION

In this course, students will study core doctrines in the Christian faith as taught in Scripture and expounded by the Christian tradition. This course will cover the general topics of God, revelation, creation, man, and sin as well as their more specific sub-topics. Students will learn how such topics are organically related in their material ordering and proportion (system), primarily following the *ordo essendi* (order of being) from a classical theistic perspective, while living out the virtues of faith, hope, and love. In so doing, we will attempt to answer two questions in systematic theology (1) “What does the whole Bible say about [fill in the blank]?”¹ and (2) “what must be true for every exegetical claim to be true?”²

§2. COURSE OBJECTIVES

By the end of this course, students should:

- Learn the doctrines covered in this course as they are drawn from Scripture and taught in the Christian tradition
- Understand how the topics are organically related to other topics in Christian theology
- Be able to interpret the Bible theologically
- Grow in the Christian virtues of faith, hope, and love
- Know how Christian doctrines fuel and shape the Christian life
- Grow in and spread a passion for the supremacy of God in all things through Jesus Christ

§3. COURSE READINGS

The following books listed below will not be provided by the professor. Students are required to gain access to the following works—whether buy, borrow, etc. Two important notes: (1) paper copies are *strongly encouraged* in class, but electronic versions are permitted, but discouraged; (2) I have chosen these books to be required to obtain because I believe they will serve you in ministry longterm.

§3.1 Required Resources

- Allen, Michael, and Scott R. Swain (eds.). *Christian Dogmatics: Reformed Theology for the Church Catholic*. Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2016. ([Amazon Link](#))
- Bavinck, Herman. *Reformed Dogmatics*. Volume 2. *God and Creation*. Edited by John Bolt. Translated by John Vriend. Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2004. ([Amazon Link](#))
- Jamieson, R. B., and Tyler R. Wittman. *Biblical Reasoning: Christological and Trinitarian Rules for Exegesis*. Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2022. ([Amazon Link](#))
- Webster, John. *God without Measure: Working Papers in Christian Theology*. Volume 1. *God and the Works of God*. London: Bloomsbury T&T Clark, 2016. ([Amazon Link](#))

¹ See Andrew David Naselli, *How to Understand and Apply the New Testament: Twelve Steps from Exegesis to Theology* (Phillipsburg, NJ: P&R Publishing, 2017), 5.

² Stephen R. Holmes, “The Nature of Theology and the Extent of the Atonement,” *Perichoresis* 16.4 (2018): 11.

§3.2 Recommended Resource

- Calvin, John. *Institutes of the Christian Religion*. LCC. Edited by John T. McNeil. Translated by Ford Lewis Battles. 2 vols. Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox Press, 1960. ([Amazon Link](#))

*All other required readings will be made available as PDF scans by the professor.***

§4. COURSE APPROACH AND PEDAGOGY

This course will be a guided socratic dialogue, which will thus require your careful attention and thoughtful interaction in class. Because I desire to teach you not just *what* to think, but also *how* to think, you must interact in class, and you will only be able to do this well by first reading the assigned materials. While we will not get into every nook and cranny of theological investigation due to the minimal time we have together, my goal is to cover the “boundary markers” of the Christian religion with a Reformed bent, and then will we be able to scratch some of the surfaces of difficult theological questions. In our discussions, *I expect you to treat others as you would want to be treated, preeminently with the virtue of love. I will not tolerate uncharitable discourse in class.* It is a good policy to first correctly understand someone before one tries to offer a critique.

§5. COURSE REQUIREMENTS AND GRADING

Students will be evaluated according to the following requirements:

Reading:	30%
Weekly Comments:	10%
Theological Definitions:	10%
Church Ministry Project:	10%
Research Paper:	20%
Research Paper presentation:	10%

5.1 Reading (30%) — Students are required to complete assigned readings before class in order to receive credit for respective readings. Students will note what percentage they have read before each class starts. This is 30% of your final grade for this course—I highly recommend that students prioritize completing the reading(s) as this will have a very significant impact on your overall grade.

5.1.1 A Note on Reading. Some professors may define “read” as “micro-read,” that is, very carefully, paying close attention to everything. I do not expect this of you, but encourage it. I will expect you to read the material with honor and diligence such that you read carefully enough to understand what the author is saying (this doesn’t mean you will retain everything). Hence, you don’t need to read every word, sentence, paragraph, or page with equally close attention (it may mean you skim some parts, breeze over headings, or very carefully read and digest other parts—you will need to use your own discretion and discernment). However, *you must read close enough to generally get a sense of what the author argues and talks about*—such reading will count as full credit.

5.2 Weekly Comments (10%) — Each class, students will write a comment, question, or critique of one of the readings the completed. Students will complete this in a spreadsheet on Moodle.

5.3 Theological Definitions (10%) — Students will be provided a sheet with 30 theological terms pertinent to this course. Students will need to define each term *in their own words* in 2–3 sentences. You are allowed to footnote resources you referenced, but take pains to try to explain it in your own words.³

³ I am taking this assignment from my former doctrine professor, Matt Crutchmer.

5.4 Church Ministry Project (10%) — Students will sit down with their pastor and discuss how one of the following topics is (a) seen in the Bible and (b) how its biblical teaching promotes true worship: (1) divine simplicity and being a single-minded person, (2) divine impassibility and the love of God, (3) the divine decree and the entrance of sin into the world, (4) creation *ex nihilo* and the Creator-creature distinction, (5) Scripture as God's word or (6) the image of God and its meaning in Reformed theology.

5.5 Research Paper (20%) — Students will turn in a final paper covering a specific topic within the broader categories taught in this course (the nature of systematic theology, God, decrees, creation, providence, revelation, Scripture, man, and sin). In terms of methodology, each paper should address their topic starting with God and treating the topic of your choice in relation to God. Papers should exceed 3,000 words (not including footnotes). All students must follow the *SBL Handbook of Style* 2nd ed. Students must include a word count at bottom of the paper and **upload a PDF online**. Papers are graded upon a 100 point scale according to the rubric below:

5.6.1 Final Paper Rubric

Students' papers will be graded on ...

1. Argumentation/Research (75 pts)
 - Use of Scripture
 - Integration of metaphysics or philosophical concepts
 - Beginning with the doctrine of God and then moving toward the topic covered in relation to God
 - Logic
 - Proper and balanced use of resources
 - Covers the appropriate related aspects of doctrine in view
2. Local Church Practice (10 pts)
 - Must include a section on how the topic should inform concrete application in the local church
3. Well and clearly written (10 pts)
 - Grammar, Syntax, and Spelling
4. Following the general guidelines of the *SBL Handbook of Style*, 2nd ed (5 pts)
 - You will be graded on whether or not you have the necessary information in footnotes & bibliography

5.7 Paper Presentation (5%) — Every student will have to “present” or discuss the main idea of their paper to the class within 2 minutes, stating their thesis, what they learned, and where there paper could be improved. Then, the student will answer questions from classmates and the professor for approximately 10 minutes.

§6. GRADING SCALE

The following scale will be used for final grades:

	B+ 89-87	C+ 79-77	D+ 69-67	
A 100-94	B 86-84	C 76-74	D 66-64	F 59-0
A- 93-90	B- 83-80	C- 73-70	D- 63-60	

§7. COURSE PROTOCOLS & STANDARDS

Assignment Expectations

Students will turn in a completed PDF to the professor. Papers will be written according to standards found in the *SBL Handbook of Style*, 2nd ed.

Late Work

I have a **NO late work policy**. No work will be accepted if it is turned in late—past the due time—unless extreme circumstances bar you from turning it in on time. Extreme circumstances include things that are out of the ordinary that would excuse you from preaching on a Sunday morning if you were a pastor. Such examples include: death of a family member or friend, unusual illness, car accident, your dog ate your computer, and other similar occurrences. I do not intend this to be burdensome, but to help you prepare for future ministry. If you are going to be a pastor or church leader, sheep in the flock will depend on you to care and feed them God's word. Sometimes this means you will turn in unfinished or "not your best" work, but that is better than nothing at all.

Academic Honesty

Oahu Theology Seminary is committed to personal integrity and honesty. All instances of dishonesty or distorting the truth to avoid negative academic or social consequences are grounds for a disciplinary response. Therefore, a policy has been established in the event of cheating or plagiarism.

Cheating

Students cheating in course work or examinations are subject to discipline. Cheating includes copying another student's work and presenting it as one's own (or allowing another person to copy one's own work) and using dishonest or prohibited methods to complete a test (or helping another person to cheat). Students who cheat will be subject to significant academic consequences including an immediate failing grade for the course.

Plagiarism

Students found plagiarizing are subject to discipline. The most common errors in handling written sources are the following:

- failure to use quotation marks when quoting,
- failure to make a thorough paraphrase when attempting to put the idea in one's own words,
- failure to credit the source of the information

Students who have been caught plagiarizing are subject to an immediate F for the course and possible disciplinary probation.

Special Needs

Any student who may require an accommodation under the provisions of the Americans with Disabilities Act should contact the course instructor in this matter as soon as possible and no later than the end of the first week of classes. Special needs must be documented.

Syllabus Revision

The professor retains the right to change the syllabus at any time.

§8. SCHEDULE

THEOLOGY 1 Numbered Ordering is suggested reading order <u>Underlined reading(s) will drive the specific class discussion</u>			
Date & Topic	Textbook Reading	Bible Reading	Assignment Due
8/18 Prolegomena: Nature & Ends of Theology	1. John Webster, "Biblical Reasoning," 128–132 [PDF] 2. Jamieson & Wittman, <i>Biblical Reasoning</i> , vii–xii & Ch. 1 3. <u>John Webster, <i>God Without Measure</i>, ch. 14</u>	• Ps 1 • Ps 27 • 1 Cor 13 • Rev 22	
8/25 God: Essence & Attributes	1. Duby, <i>Jesus and the God of Classical Theism</i> , 22–32 [PDF] 2. Bavinck, <i>Reformed Dogmatics</i> , 29–41, 97–110; 149–177 3. Jamieson & Wittman, <i>Biblical Reasoning</i> , ch. 4 4. <u>Aquinas, <i>Summa theologiae</i> Ia.2.3; Ia.3–4 (pp. 20–43) [PDF]</u>	• Isa 40–48	• Weekly Comments
9/1 God: The Holy Trinity	1. <u>Swain, "Divine Trinity," ch. 4 in <i>Christian Dogmatics</i></u> 2. Jamieson & Wittman, <i>Biblical Reasoning</i> , chs. 5–6 3. Augustine, <i>De Trinitate</i> bk. 5 [PDF] 4. Webster, GWM ch. 3	• Deut 6 • Mark 12 • 2 Cor 3	• Weekly Comments
9/8 Divine Decrees	1. Bavinck, <i>Reformed Dogmatics</i> , 341–347; 370–374 2. Maastricht, <i>Theoretical-Practical Theology</i> , 1.3.1 [PDF] 3. <u>Swain, "Covenant of Redemption," ch. 5 in <i>Christian Dogmatics</i></u>	• Eph 1	• Weekly Comments
9/15 Creation & Providence	1. Bavinck, <i>Reformed Dogmatics</i> , 407–408; 416–420; 426–439; 591–598; 604–619 2. Davison, <i>Participation in God</i> , 42–52 [PDF] 3. <u>Webster, GWM, chs. 7 & 9</u>	• Gen 1 • Ps 104	• Weekly Comments
9/22 Revelation & Scripture	1. <u>John Calvin, <i>Institutes</i>, Book 1, chs. 1–7</u> 2. Vanhoozer, "Holy Scripture," ch. 2 in <i>Christian Dogmatics</i> 3. Beeke & Smalley, <i>Essentials of Reformed ST</i> , chs. 6–7 [PDF]	• Ps 19 • Rom 1–2:15 • 2 Tim 3:16–17	• Weekly Comments
9/29 Man & Sin	1. Bavinck, <i>Reformed Dogmatics</i> , 530–580 2. Augustine • <i>Enchiridion</i> chs. 3–4 [PDF] • <i>City of God</i> 12.1–8 [PDF]	• Gen 1–3 • Rom 5:12–21 • Jas 1	• Weekly Comments • Church Project
10/6 Fall Break	No Class. Work on Final Paper.		• Final Paper due Oct 8th, 11:59pm
10/13 Paper Presentations	1. Webster, GWM, ch. 2 2. Classmate papers (Skim)		• Weekly Comments on Classmate Papers • Paper Presentations • Theological Definitions